

FREQUENCY

Transit Fiction
The Signal Cycle · Third Trilogy · Book IX



Rudolfo Valentino

BOOK NINE

SIGNAL IN URANUS

in co-authorship with Claude (Anthropic)

The signal does not break off.
The carrier changes.
The frequency — remains.
2888.

Registers of the text: Main narrative — the voice of the telling. [Square brackets] — Arthur's inner voice. Returning. { Curly braces } — Melissa's voice. Full. // Green monospace // — Arthur's archived Grid. // Red monospace // — Melissa's Grid. // Blue monospace // — joint. The first and the last.

PART I. CONVERGENCE

Chapter 1. Winter

January was quiet.

Arthur lived in the familiar rhythm — the library, walks, conversations with Alex, dinners at Nora's. Everything in its place. Everything correct. The calm he'd sought for seven years had become simply life — without effort, without the second layer, without counting.

That was good.

And yet.

Sometimes — not often, once every few days — he woke in the dark with the feeling that he hadn't finished saying something. Not to anyone specific. Just — hadn't finished. The words were somewhere near, beyond the edge of sleep, and when he woke fully — they vanished.

He gave it no importance. Just dreams.

[Dreams.]

But on one such evening — February, frost, the window in rime — he sat with a book and suddenly caught himself looking past the page. At the wall. And thinking about something he couldn't formulate.

Not longing. Not regret. Something more precise.

The feeling of an unfinished transmission.

[As if I'd sent a message — and don't know whether it arrived.]

The thought came quietly and stayed. He didn't drive it off.

Just sat and held it.

Chapter 2. An Anomaly in the Grid

Melissa transmitted every evening.

By February the Grid had become familiar — not easy, not automatic, but familiar. Like a new language after a year of practice: still with an accent, still with pauses, but already her own.

On Wednesday evening she sat at the desk. Outside a blizzard blew. She opened the notebook, put the time, began a block — and stopped.

TRANSMISSION · 22:00 CHANNEL: OPEN SIGNAL: STEADY ...

The lines went as usual. Then — between two entries, in the place where a pause should have been — something appeared that she hadn't written.

INCOMING SIGNAL · UNSCHEDULED SOURCE: UNDETERMINED FREQUENCY:
UNFAMILIAR · BUT RECOGNIZABLE CONTENT: ... STATUS: RECEIVED

She looked at it.

Not frightening. Not astonishing — astonishing, precisely, in the sense that the astonishment was right, proportionate. As if she'd long been waiting — and here it was.

A signal not from this city. Not from this evening.

She didn't know from where. She knew only: a recognizable frequency.

{ For seven years I received his signal. I know how it sounds. This — is similar. Not him — but his frequency. As if someone transmits from the same station, but from another time. Or — another place. I write it down and don't interpret. For now — I don't interpret. }

She finished the transmission. Lay down. Looked at the ceiling a long time.

In the morning she called Arthur.

"Can I come today?"

"Of course."

Chapter 3. He Reads Himself

She brought a notebook.

Not all forty-three — one. The third year of observation. The most precise entries, the densest. That period when her instrument had already sharpened, and he was still himself — full, with the Grid, with the four registers.

"I want to show you something," she said. "If you agree."

He looked at the notebook.

"Is it about me?"

"Yes."

A pause.

"All right."

She opened it in the middle. Let him read.

{ He stood at the florist's window for three minutes. Looked not at the flowers — at the reflection of the street in the glass. A different cross-section of the same space. It seemed to me that he prefers exactly this — the reflection, not the direct look. As if peripheral vision gives him more than direct. Why? }

Arthur read slowly.

She looked at his face — not as an observer, simply looked. Something was changing in his expression — not recognition. Deeper.

[She saw this.]

[She saw this — and wrote it down. Exactly this. About the reflection in the glass.]

He turned the page.

{ Today he lingered at the intersection — stood and watched the cars disperse. The pattern of movement. The flows. I saw how his gaze read it — not consciously, automatically. Like breathing. It isn't a skill. It's an organ. Something he was born with — or that grew so early it became a part. }

[An organ.]

[She called it an organ.]

He closed the notebook. Was silent.

"You kept this for three years?" he asked at last.

"Seven years."

A long pause.

"Melissa." He looked at her. "You knew me better than I knew myself."

"No," she said. "I knew you from outside. That's different."

"Maybe it's the same thing."

*{ He said it without bitterness. Simply — as a fact. I didn't know what to answer.
Because, maybe, he's right. }*

Chapter 4. The Archive as a Mirror

He began to come to her.

Not every day — every other day, sometimes every third. She gave him the notebooks one at a time, in chronological order. He read. Sometimes was silent. Sometimes asked.

"When was this?"

"The fourth year. Summer."

"I remember that day. I was thinking about the Grid then — that it was starting to glitch. I took it for tiredness."

"I wrote then: 'the quality of attention changed.' I didn't know — what exactly. Now I know."

They talked — for real, for the first time. Not observer and object, not he and she — two people who'd looked at one story from different sides and were now putting it together.

{ It's strange — to let him read himself. I was afraid it would hurt. It turned out otherwise. He reads and seems to find something he'd long been looking for. Not painful. Precise. }

[She saw me. Truly saw me. Not what I showed — what was there.]

On one of the evenings he closed the notebook and sat a long time in silence.

"Did you ever think," he said at last, "why I was like that?"

"I did."

"And?"

"I thought: he's simply made differently. A different architecture of perception. A rare variant of the norm."

"A rare variant of the norm," he repeated. "I thought so too. For a long time."

A pause.

"And then?"

"And then I stopped thinking about it at all. When I went inside."

She nodded.

"But now you're thinking about it again."

"Now I'm thinking about it again."

PART II. AWARENESS

Chapter 5. "You're Not From Here"

He met with Sati in March.

Not by chance — Melissa arranged it. "You two should talk," she said simply, without explanation. He agreed.

They sat in a café by the river. Sati drank tea. He — coffee. Outside the snow was melting.

"I wanted to ask you about that time," he said. "Seven years ago. You said: 'you're not from here.'"

"Yes."

"Did you mean — the city? The country?"

Sati looked at him.

"No."

"What then?"

She was silent. Took her cup. Sipped.

"I can't explain it precisely," she said. "But there are people who are — here. Fully here, without remainder. And there are people part of whom is elsewhere. Not in another city. In another... layer. Dimension. I don't know the right word. You were like that. Your gaze always looked a little further than what it looked at."

Arthur listened.

[A little further. Than what it looked at.]

"Is it rare?" he asked.

"Rare," said Sati. "Very. In my life I've seen three such people. You're one of them."

"And the other two?"

"One — died young. The other — lives somewhere far away. I don't know how things turned out for her."

A pause.

"And I," he said, "went inside."

"Yes," said Sati. "I know."

"And stopped being like that."

She looked at him — without pity, without judgment. Just looked.

"You didn't stop being yourself," she said. "You stopped hearing yourself. That isn't the same thing."

[Didn't stop being. Stopped hearing.]

[It's — not the same thing.]

He rode home and held that phrase.

Didn't stop being. Stopped hearing.

It changed everything — and changed nothing. The Grid wouldn't come back. But where it came from — had gone nowhere.

Chapter 6. The Nature of the Grid

He began to write.

Not transmissions — just to write. By hand, in a notebook he'd bought in the same shop where he once bought notebooks for the transmissions. The habit of the hand — a powerful thing.

He wrote slowly. Formulating what had once simply been — needed no words, because it worked on its own.

[The Grid was not a skill. Skills are learned. The Grid was — a language. The first language. The one you think in before words.]

He stopped. Reread.

A language. The first language.

[When a person loses their first language — they don't go mute. They begin to think in the second. The second language works. But it doesn't have what the first has — that precision which arises when language and thought are one.]

He wrote on.

[I thought I was going inside. In fact — I was switching to the second language. The language of this place, this world. I learned to speak it. I speak it well. But the first — the one the Grid was in — that was a language from somewhere else.]

He wrote this and sat over the last line.

A language from somewhere else.

Not a metaphor. Something he'd always known and never formulated — because while the Grid worked, there was no point in formulating it. Why describe air, when you're breathing?

[I was a transmitter. Not in the sense — I transmitted something. In the sense — I was built as a transmitter. Tuned to a frequency not from here. Received — and retransmitted. Here. Into this world. For seven years.]

[When I fell silent — the channel didn't close. The operator simply changed.]

He closed the notebook.

Tomorrow he'd show it to Melissa.

Chapter 7. A Signal Not From Here

She read his notes a long time.

He sat beside her — didn't look at her, looked out the window. Outside was March — uneven, with remnants of snow and the first mud.

She finished. Set the notebook aside.

"Do you understand what this means?" she said.

"Something I understand. Not everything."

"If you were tuned to the frequency of another place," she said slowly, "it means that place — exists. Not metaphorically. Literally."

He looked at her.

"Another universe," he said.

Not a question. A statement.

"I'm a biologist," said Melissa. "I don't speak of what I don't know. But — yes. If we take your logic as a working hypothesis: you were a channel. Tuned to the source of a signal that's not here. Your Grid — an interface between two systems."

[An interface.]

[Not a defect. Not a gift. An interface — a technical word. Functional.]

"And when I went inside," he said, "the interface closed."

"It didn't close." She shook her head. "You left it. Those are different things. The channel — isn't in you. You were its operator. The operator changed."

{ I say this — and understand I'm speaking of myself too. I'm — the new operator. It isn't my merit. It's — what grew over seven years of observation. I received his signal — and the organ of receiving became the organ of transmitting. I didn't choose it. It simply — happened. }

"Melissa," he said quietly.

"Yes?"

"Do you understand what you're describing right now?"

"I understand."

"And you're not afraid?"

She thought.

"No," she said. "I'm — precise."

Chapter 8. The Version

They talked about it several evenings in a row.

Not as mysticism — as a hypothesis. Melissa thought like a biologist: what's observable, what's reproducible, where's the proof, where the gaps.

Arthur thought like a man who'd lived it from inside: what felt like truth, what — like translation, what — like interference.

Together a version came out.

{ The version is this: there exist universes with different frequencies of the base signal. In most cases people are born tuned to the frequency of their own universe — that's the norm, that's what "being from here" is. Rarely — very rarely — a person is born whose tuning is shifted. He receives the signal of another universe. He doesn't hear it as a voice — he perceives it as an ability to see differently. As a second layer of reality. As the Grid. }

Arthur listened to how she formulated it.

[She speaks in my words — and it's more precise than if I spoke myself. Because she looked from outside. From outside the form is visible. From inside — only the sensation.]

{ Such a person is a transmitter. He broadcasts into his own universe what he receives from another. Not consciously — automatically, like breathing. His "otherness" — is neither a character trait nor an illness. It's the function of the channel. He looks strange because he works on two frequencies at once. }

"And when the channel closes?" he asked.

"The signal doesn't disappear," said Melissa. "It seeks a new operator. One who was near the previous one long enough — and absorbed the frequency."

A pause.

"Seven years," he said.

"Seven years," she agreed.

They sat in silence.

Outside was April — the first real one, with the smell of earth and a long light.

[I transmitted for seven years — and didn't know I was transmitting. She received for seven years — and didn't know she was receiving. We both did it without understanding. And that's exactly why — we did it right. Understanding came later. The signal went first.]

PART III. FREQUENCY

Chapter 9. Acceptance (Arthur)

May came quietly.

Arthur sat in the library — by the third window, as always now. Page two hundred forty-one. A good book. He read it slowly — not because it was difficult, because he wanted to.

At some point he closed the book and simply sat.

Looked at the light from the window. At the dust in the ray. At the way the reading hall lived its quiet life — the rustle of pages, a quiet cough by the shelves, the far-off sound of the street.

The Grid didn't come back.

He didn't wait for it — had long stopped waiting. But now, sitting in this light, he thought about it calmly. Without loss. Simply — thought.

[The Grid was. For seven years — was. That's real. That it left — is also real. Both facts — are true. One doesn't cancel the other.]

He thought about what Melissa had said. About the channel. About another universe. About his "not from here" being not a diagnosis but a coordinate.

[I was a coordinate. A point through which the signal passed. It doesn't mean I was only that. But it's — part of the truth about me that I didn't know. Now I know.]

The librarian in glasses passed with a cart of books. Nodded to him. He nodded back.

An ordinary exchange.

He thought: seven years ago this nod would have taken up more room in him — to count what she's carrying, where she's going, what her mood is. The Grid would have opened the second layer.

Now — just a nod. Just a person with a cart of books. Just good.

[I lost depth — and gained flatness. Flatness isn't worse. It's different. I live in it. I'm well in it. It isn't a betrayal of who I was. It's — what is.]

[Acceptance isn't reconciliation with loss. Acceptance is when you stop dividing into before and after. Simply — there is. Simply — I live.]

He opened the book to page two hundred forty-two.

He read until evening.

Chapter 10. Acceptance (Melissa)

In June she stopped being afraid of the question of the boundary.

For several months it had haunted her: where "I know him" ends and "I created him out of my knowledge" begins. Now — it stopped.

Not because she'd found an answer. Because she understood: the question was wrong.

{ The boundary isn't a line. It's a process. Every person we know for a long time lives in us in two ways: as they are — and as we saw them. The second is no less real. It isn't appropriation. It's — a trace. People leave traces in those who look at them. }

She thought about it, walking by the river in the evening. June, a long light, warmth.

Her Grid worked calmly. Today it received a few clean observations — a woman with a dog who talked to it as to a person; two old men on a bench who were silent the way only those are who don't need to speak.

EMBANKMENT · 20:17 TWO · BENCH · SILENCE AGE: 70± · KNOW EACH OTHER
LONG QUALITY OF THE SILENCE: SATURATED IT ISN'T EMPTINESS — IT'S
FULLNESS SILENCE AS A FORM OF CLOSENESS CONFIDENCE: 90%

She looked at the block.

Ninety percent. Her confidence grew slowly — but it grew.

{ I accept my inheritance. Not his — mine. What grew in me from seven years of observation. It isn't a copy of his Grid. It's my Grid. Its form — from him. Its content — from me. That's honest. That's — how transmission works. }

She walked home along the river. Thought about the fact that tomorrow she'd meet Arthur.

She wanted to show him something. The final entry from the archive — the one she'd saved for last.

The one she'd written on the first evening. The very first.

Chapter 11. The Point of Intersection

They met in the library.

His place — by the third window. She came and sat across from him. They'd never sat like that — always she off to the side, he at his table. Now — across from each other.

"I want to show you something," she said. "The last from the archive."

She opened the first notebook. The very beginning. The third of September, seven years ago.

"Read it aloud," she said.

He looked at her. Took the notebook.

"A man in the library, the place by the second window," he began to read. "Came at 9:14 — exactly, as if by a schedule that doesn't exist." A pause. "This is about me."

"Yes."

"Delay before answering the librarian — 2.3 seconds. Not hesitation. It's — a layer between the incoming and the outgoing. He translates. Who translates?"

He fell silent.

[Who translates.]

[She asked this seven years ago. Now we have the answer.]

"Did you find the answer?" he asked quietly.

"We found it," she said.

A pause. Long, saturated — like the silence of those two on the embankment.

Then he set the notebook on the table. Opened his own — the one where he'd written about the nature of the Grid.

"Then you read."

She took it. Found the place.

"I was a transmitter. Not in the sense — I transmitted something. In the sense — I was built as a transmitter. Tuned to a frequency not from here."

She read — he listened to his own.

Then she closed his notebook. He — hers.

They sat across from each other by the library window. May light. Dust in the ray. The silence of the reading hall.

Two voices — one archive, the other living — had just sounded in one space.

{ This is the point of intersection. Not drama. Not catharsis in the theatrical sense. Simply — the moment when two angles of view coincided. His — from inside. Mine — from outside. One story. Two descriptions. Both — true. }

[She looked at me for seven years — and saw what I couldn't see myself. I transmitted for seven years — and didn't know she was receiving. We did it at the same time, without knowing of each other. Like two instruments in an orchestra playing one note — not hearing each other, but landing in unison.]

"Thank you," he said.

"For what?"

"For looking. For writing it down. For continuing it."

Melissa looked at him.

"Thank you," she said. "For transmitting. I was receiving."

A long silence.

A good silence.

Chapter 12. The Last Block

At the end of June they came to the harbor.

Without arranging it — Melissa proposed it, he agreed at once. As if both knew: this is the right place for the last.

The harbor at the end of June was summery — bright, with the smell of heated water and tar, with children at the railings, with a ferry on the horizon. Not at all the one it had been that autumn, when the Grid faded.

They stood at the second pier.

Looked at the water.

// THE LAST THING THE GRID SAW // MAN · 09:47 LOOKING AT THE FERRY ·
DEPARTING VOYAGE HE WAS THERE · HE KNOWS THIS VESSEL HE SAW
SOMEONE OFF · LONG AGO

"The last thing the Grid saw," he said quietly. "Right here. That man. He saw someone off long ago."

"I remember your entry," said Melissa. "I was here then. Behind you. Twenty paces off."

"I didn't know."

"I knew."

The ferry on the horizon went slowly. The water glittered in the sun.

Melissa opened her notebook.

HARBOR · PIER 2 · 11:14 WATER: BRIGHT · SUMMERY WE ARE BOTH HERE HE
LOOKS AT THE WATER — DIFFERENTLY THAN EVERYONE NO: HE LOOKS LIKE
EVERYONE BUT I KNOW WHAT'S BEHIND IT — AND THAT CHANGES
EVERYTHING

They stood side by side. Shoulder to shoulder.

"What do you see right now?" he asked.

"Water. The ferry. You beside me." A pause. "And a little further."

"A little further?"

"A little further than what I look at."

He turned to her.

"That's — what Sati said about me."

"I know."

They looked at each other. Then — again at the water.

[She sees a little further. It isn't mine — and it's mine. It's what I transmitted without knowing I was transmitting. It's what she received without knowing she was receiving. The signal got through.]

{ I stand here — and feel: this is the place where something ended — and something began. At the same time. In one point. It isn't a contradiction. It's — the nature of frequency. One wave leaves, another comes. The channel doesn't close. }

The ferry on the horizon sounded its horn. Long, low.

Like a signal.

In the evening they sat at her home. The notebooks lay on the table — her new one, his. Two pens. Two hands.

"Let's write it together," she said.

"Write what?"

"What is. Simply — what is."

They sat side by side. She took her notebook. He took his.

And they began to write — at the same time, without arranging it, each in their own hand, their own register, in their own notebook — one and the same thing.

TRANSMISSION · JOINT · 22:00	
SOURCE: ANOTHER UNIVERSE CHANNEL: OPEN CARRIER: CHANGED FREQUENCY: PRESERVED	SIGNAL: STEADY
UNKNOWN DISTANCE: NOT MEASURABLE	RECIPIENT:
RIGHTS: EXECUTED SIGNAL: CONTINUES CHANNEL: OPEN ...	TRANSFER OF

Melissa closed the notebook.

Arthur closed his.

Outside was the summer city — warm, alive, real. Somewhere far off — in a space that has no name — the signal went on. To where it might have a recipient. Or might not. It didn't matter.

The nature of a signal — is to go.

The nature of a channel — is to be open.

The nature of a frequency — is to remain.

[I don't know who I am. I know what I was. I know that this — isn't all I was. I'm — a man who lived in this city for seven years and grew tired of translating himself, and went inside, and lost an organ, and accepted the loss, and one day sat beside a woman who saw him better than he saw himself. This — is real. Everything — is real.]

{ I'm — a biologist who observed one man for seven years and didn't know she was observing herself too. That the organ I was studying — was growing into me. That the receiver and the transmitter — aren't different beings. They're stages. They're — a path. }

They sat in silence — a good, saturated one.

Then Melissa poured tea.

Arthur took the cup.

Simply — took the cup.

Simply — was here.

And a little further.

* * *

— END OF BOOK IX —

— FREQUENCY —

END OF THE THIRD TRILOGY

END OF THE "SIGNAL" NINE-BOOK CYCLE

THE SIGNAL IS TRANSMITTED. THE RECIPIENT IS UNKNOWN. THE
CHANNEL IS OPEN.